

Language work: the passive

A Look at the HELP box. How do you make the passive in your language? How different is it to English?

HELP box

The passive

We form the passive with the verb **be** + the past participle of the main verb. When we mention the agent, we use **by**.

The passive is often used in technical writing to give an objective tone.

- Present simple passive
*Information **is transmitted by** devices such as the telephone, radio, TV or ...*
- Present continuous passive
*New technologies **are being devised** to allow you to watch TV on your mobile.*
- Past simple passive
*The term **cyborg** **was invented by** M Clynes and N Kline in 1960.*
- Past continuous passive
*My TV **was being repaired**, so I couldn't watch the match.*
- Present perfect passive
*It **has been predicted** that about one third of all work could eventually be performed outside the workplace.*
- Past perfect passive
*The system **had been infected** by a virus.*
- Future simple passive
*In the next few years, GPS chips **will also be incorporated** into most mobile phones.*
- Modal verbs in the passive
*It has been predicted that about one-third of all work **could** eventually **be performed** outside the workplace.*

C Complete these sentences with the passive form of the verbs in brackets.

- 1 Microprocessors (make) _____ of silicon.
- 2 Call centres (use) _____ to deal with telephone enquiries.
- 3 In recent years, most mobile phones (equip) _____ with Bluetooth.
- 4 GPS (develop) _____ in the 1970s as a military navigation system.
- 5 Sorry about the mess – the computers (replace) _____ at the moment.
- 6 In the near future, the Internet (access) _____ more frequently from PDAs and mobile phones than from desktop computers.
- 7 Networks (can connect) _____ via satellite.
- 8 I had to use my laptop this morning while my PC (fix) _____.